

Word family: **reference / references / referenced / referencing / refer / referral / referee**

Base word: reference

Forms: references, referenced, referencing

Closely related forms: refer, referral, referee

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / related verb and nouns (相關動詞及名詞)

Your sentence:

> “There are reading areas, **reference sections**, exhibitions, and sometimes public talks or cultural activities.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **reference** means **information or materials used for checking facts, looking things up, or obtaining reliable background information**.

A **reference section** in a library is an area containing materials such as dictionaries, encyclopedias, directories, atlases, manuals, or other sources mainly used for consultation.

繁體中文： **參考資料；供查閱資料、核實資訊或尋找背景資料之用的**

中文翻譯：

> “...reading areas, **reference sections**, exhibitions...”

「.....閱讀區、**參考資料區**、展覽區.....」

Here:

reference section = 圖書館中供查閱參考資料的區域

1. **reference = source of information used for checking/consulting (參考資料) — 參考資料 ; 參考來源**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A source that you consult in order to obtain, check, or confirm information.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The library has a large **reference section**.”

「這間圖書館有一個很大的**參考資料區**。」

Practice 2

> “This dictionary is a useful **reference**.”

「這本字典是很有用的**參考資料**。」

Practice 3

> “Keep the manual for future **reference**.”

「保留這本手冊以供日後**參考**。」

reference = 用來查閱、核實或獲取資訊的資料來源

Common:

- * reference book
- * reference material
- * reference section
- * for reference
- * future reference

2. **reference** = mention of someone/something (提及) — 提到；提及；言及

Reference can mean an act of mentioning or alluding to a person, event, idea, etc.

Practice 4

> “The article makes several **references** to climate change.”

「這篇文章多次**提到**氣候變化。」

Practice 5

> “There was no **reference** to the earlier incident.”

「文中沒有**提及**較早前的事件。」

reference to something = 對某人 / 某事的提及或談及

This is a major distinct sense.

3. **reference = citation/source acknowledgement (學術) — 引用 ; 參考文獻**

In academic writing, **reference** can mean a source that has been cited or listed to support information.

Practice 6

> “The essay includes twenty **references**.”

「這篇論文列出了二十項**參考文獻**。」

Practice 7

> “Check the **references** at the end of the article.”

「查看文章末尾的**參考文獻**。」

reference = 在文章、研究或報告中列出的資料來源或引用來源

This is related to Meaning 1 but is useful enough to show separately because the academic convention is very specific.

4. **reference = recommendation about a person (推薦 / 證明) — 推薦信 ; 推薦人資料 ; 證明**

Reference can refer to a statement from someone who can comment on another person's character, work, or suitability.

Practice 8

> “The employer asked for two **references**.”

「僱主要求提供兩位**推薦人 / 證明人**。」

Practice 9

> “Her former manager gave her an excellent **reference**.”

「她的前任經理為她提供了一份很好的**推薦證明**。」

reference = 由熟悉某人的人提供、用來證明其能力或品格的推薦意見

This is a major employment/education sense.

5. **reference** = identifying number/code (編號) — 參考編號；編碼

Reference can mean a number, code, or identifier used to locate or track information.

Practice 10

> “Please quote your booking **reference**.”

「請提供你的預訂**編號**。」

Practice 11

> “The case has a unique **reference number**.”

「這宗個案有一個獨特的**參考編號**。」

reference = 用來識別、查找或追蹤某項記錄的編號或代碼

This is a distinct practical sense.

6. **reference** = standard for comparison (基準) — 參照；參考基準

Reference can mean a standard or point used for comparison or orientation.

Practice 12

> “Use the diagram as a **reference**.”

「把這張圖作為**參照**。」

Practice 13

> “The measurements were taken from a fixed **reference point**.”

「這些測量是以一個固定**參考點**為基準進行的。」

reference = 用來比較、定位或判斷其他事物的基準點

This is an important technical/general sense.

7. **reference = verb, mention or cite (動詞) — 提及 ; 引用**

As a verb, **reference** means to mention or cite a source/person/topic.

Practice 14

> “The report **references** several earlier studies.”

「這份報告**引用**了幾項較早的研究。」

Practice 15

> “She **referenced** the incident in her speech.”

「她在演講中**提到了**那宗事件。」

reference = 在文字或說話中提及、引用某個來源或事物

This is a major verb sense.

Related form: **refer**

Refer is extremely important and has several distinct patterns.

refer to = mention / mean (提到 / 指的是)

> “The article refers to three studies.”

「這篇文章**提到**三項研究。」

> “What does this word refer to?”

「這個詞**指的是**甚麼？」

refer someone to = direct someone elsewhere (轉介)

> “The doctor referred me to a specialist.”

「醫生把我**轉介**給專科醫生。」

These are family extensions rather than additional senses of **reference** itself.

Related form: **referral**

Referral usually means the act of directing someone to another person/service.

Practice 16

> “You may need a doctor’s **referral**.”

「你可能需要醫生的**轉介信 / 轉介**。」

referral = 轉介；介紹某人去接受另一項服務

Related form: **referee**

Referee is historically related to **refer**, but in modern English it is strongly lexicalized.

It can mean:

- * a sports official who enforces rules
- * in some varieties of English, a person who provides a job/academic reference

Because the meanings are independent enough, I would treat **referee** as a lexical-family extension rather than fold it into the core **reference** entry.

Important distinction: **reference** vs **source**

source

= where information comes from

reference

= a source you consult, cite, or use for checking

A source becomes a reference when it is used for support, consultation, or citation.

Important distinction: **reference** vs **mention**

mention

= briefly say something

reference

can be more formal and may include:

- * mention
- * allusion
- * citation

> make a reference to something

is more formal than:

> mention something

Important distinction: **reference vs citation**

citation

usually means the formal acknowledgement of a source in academic or legal writing.

reference

is broader and can mean:

- * the source itself
- * the entry in a reference list
- * a mention
- * a standard for comparison

So all citations are references in a broad sense, but not all references are citations.

Important distinction: **reference vs recommendation**

In employment:

reference

= evidence/testimony from someone who knows you

recommendation

= positive support or endorsement

A reference can be factual and not necessarily enthusiastic.

Important distinction: **reference vs referral**

reference

= source, mention, recommendation, code, benchmark

referral

= sending/directing someone to another person or service

Very different despite the related word family.

Countability note

Reference is usually countable in many senses:

- > a reference
- > several references

But in fixed expressions such as:

- > for reference
- > with reference to

it behaves more abstractly.

Useful expression: **for reference** — 供參考

Practice 17

> “I’ve attached the old report for **reference**.”

「我附上舊報告供你**參考**。」

Useful expression: **with reference to — 關於；就……而言**

Practice 18

> “With **reference to** your email, we have reviewed the issue.”

「**關於**你的電郵，我們已經檢視有關問題。」

This is formal and less common than:

> regarding

> about

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **reference**

* **references**

* **referenced**

* **referencing**

* **refer**

* **referral**

* **referee**

The important semantic branches are:

* source for consultation

* mention/allusion

* citation

* personal recommendation

* identifying code

* comparison standard

* verb: mention/cite

The Golden Manual's principle applies strongly here: **reference book**, **reference section**, **reference material**, and **for reference** all belong to the same consultation-information branch and should not be split merely because the surrounding noun changes.

Master comparison

| Form / sense

| MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |

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reference — information source 用來查閱、核實或取得資訊的參考資料 / 來源	
reference — mention 對某人、某事或某觀點的提及 / 言及	
reference — academic citation 文章或研究中列出的資料來源 / 參考文獻	
reference — person/job 證明某人能力、品格或工作表現的推薦意見 / 推薦人資料	
reference — code/number 用來識別、查找或追蹤記錄的編號 / 代碼	
reference — benchmark 用來比較、定位或判斷其他事物的參照基準	
reference — verb 在文字或說話中引用或提及	
refer / referral 提到、指向；轉介 / 轉介行為	

For your original sentence

> “There are reading areas, ****reference sections****, exhibitions...”

The exact meaning is:

****reference = 用來查閱可靠資訊或背景資料的資料類別****

So:

> ****reference section****

= ****參考資料區 / 參考書區****

For your database, I would count ****6 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****reference****:

1. ****source/material used for consultation****
2. ****mention/allusion****
3. ****academic citation/reference****
4. ****employment/academic recommendation****
5. ****identifying code/number****
6. ****standard/point for comparison****

I would keep the verb ****reference = cite/mention**** aligned with #2/#3, and keep ****refer / referral / referee**** as family extensions rather than inflate the noun count.